

Instructions for your Herbst[®] appliance

Congratulations! You have started an important stage in your orthodontic treatment. This is the best time to correct the discrepancy with your bite—while you are young and still growing.

The Herbst appliance reduces an overbite by encouraging the lower jaw forward and the upper molars backward. By stimulating your lower jaw to grow at a more rapid pace, the appliance allows it to “catch up” with your upper jaw to prevent future problems. The Herbst appliance will remain in your mouth for about 12 months, or if you are an adult, 12–14 months. We are thrilled by the dramatic difference the Herbst appliance will make in the long-term quality of your life and smile!

What to expect in the first two weeks

- ▶ Your teeth will not “fit” together and will be sore for 7–14 days.
- ▶ You can use sugar-free gum on any areas that are causing irritation to your cheek or lip area. Chew a piece of sugar-free (xylitol) gum; break off a small piece, depending on the size of the area you will be placing it on, rub it between your fingers, and then place it over the bothersome area.
- ▶ You will need to eat soft foods for 10–14 days.
- ▶ The assistant will place small adjusters on your sidebars. The adjusters will slide up and down on the sidebars which is normal.

What to expect in the first year

- ▶ Your Herbst appliance will be checked every 8–12 weeks. Periodic adjustments may be made.
- ▶ Your Herbst appliance will be over-corrected and cause an under-bite (bottom teeth move in front of upper teeth) to allow for some relaxation of muscle structure after it is removed. This may happen as soon as the first Herbst adjustment appointment.
- ▶ Braces are required during and after the Herbst placement to align your teeth and bite.



Taking care of your teeth during treatment

Excellent oral hygiene with your Herbst appliance is essential for keeping your teeth and gums healthy. If you need recommendations or have further questions, Kristo Orthodontics can help guide your care regimen and help you select the best products for your teeth and appliance.

- ▶ Brush your teeth, gums, and Herbst sidebars after every meal and at bedtime with a soft-bristled toothbrush.
Make sure you spend enough time in each area to remove all the plaque and to massage your gums. If your gums get red or puffy and bleed, massage them with a toothbrush and rinse with an antiseptic oral cleanser such as Peroxyl (Colgate) and saltwater rinses.
- ▶ Floss at least once a day.
- ▶ Rinse with Crest ProRinse mouthwash twice a day—once in the morning and once after dinner. Crest ProRinse can be purchased almost anywhere you buy toothpaste.
- ▶ If any part of your Herbst appliance comes loose, call our office. Save the loose pieces and bring them with you to your appointment.



Protecting your orthodontic appliance while eating

When taking care of your Herbst appliance, softer foods are recommended—especially after an appointment when your mouth may be sore. As a general rule, if you have to question whether you can eat something with your appliance, it's better to take it slow or avoid it altogether.

- ▶ Avoid eating hard, chewy, or sticky food items such as Tootsie Rolls®, caramels, Starburst®, Skittles®, ice cubes, beef jerky, hard granola bars, suckers/lollipops, and popcorn kernels (fully popped is fine).
- ▶ Do not chew on non-food items such as pens, pencils, or fingernails.
- ▶ Some foods, such as bagels or pizza crust, are fine to enjoy as long as they are cut into smaller pieces which won't damage your appliance. For example, slice your apples, break up tacos or nachos into bite-sized pieces before eating, etc.